



Practical Examiners Report 2025 Stage Two MW Exam

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Introduction

Practical Chair: Peter Marks MW

This year's practical exam resulted in 16 passes out of 132 candidates sitting the exam. The pass rate of 12.1% is the same as last year when we had 17 passes, but there were more candidates (140) sitting the exam in 2024. Before moderation there were only 5 clear passes; thus, 11 additional passes were achieved after moderation.

Paper two was the most challenging for candidates with only 12 passes (50.3% average mark) while paper one had 20 passes (53.3% average mark) and paper three scored the best with 23 passes (56.1% average mark). Two of the three averages are lower than last year's (55.5%, 55.1% and 53.4% for papers one, two and three respectively); paper three improved on its 2024 average. Worse still is the number of candidates earning an overall grade of D or lower: 41.7% this year, compared with about one-third in 2024.

Some might interpret these results as the examiners making the practical exam more difficult, but that is not the case. In fact, more recent candidates — those sitting the practical exam for the first or second time — accounted for eight of this year's 16 passes. This indicates that passing the practical exam is achievable. During my moderation of the papers, however, two themes stood out; these are also highlighted in the paper chairs' reports.

The first theme was an inability to read the wine accurately. Too many candidates started on the wrong foot because they could not reliably identify the wine's components — alcohol, acidity, tannin and residual sugar. Often a candidate will latch onto a single feature in a wine's appearance, aroma and flavour characteristics and then justify that initial assumption by forcing the wine's components or structure to fit it. We call this shoehorning, and it was a significant issue this year.

This problem was especially evident when wines were not easily identifiable — for example, the mixed bag on paper 2, question three — where many candidates failed to consider alternative possibilities and left themselves little room to earn marks. A candidate who reads the wine correctly and makes a logical deduction about its origin or variety can still achieve a pass. By contrast, poor tasting ability not only limits marks for identification but also leads to incorrect statements about the wine's quality, style and commercial appeal.

Recognising quality is vitally important: it accounted for more than 20% of the marks in this year's exams. This was the other major reason many candidates failed. For example, calling a Côtes du Rhône (Paper 2) a Châteauneuf-du-Pape, or describing the Ruby Port in paper three as a vintage Port, undermines the examiner's confidence. Candidates should not panic when asked to describe quality in a particular context — for example, "globally" (paper two) or "with reference to its classification" (paper three). Instead, pause and think carefully about precisely what the examiners are asking.

We understand that wine #11 on paper one may have caused confusion because the wine was a blend while the question asked for a grape variety. Peter Mitchell MW discusses this in his report. If a wine is included in the exam as a single varietal, that indicates that the label or the published details refer only to a single varietal. For reasons of confidentiality, we cannot discuss the exact details with producers in advance; if it later emerges that a small percentage of another variety was present, we will of course take that into account when marking.

Each of the paper chairs has written an excellent, detailed report with valuable insights, so please review these carefully and take their advice to heart. I should also mention that the exam and study programme teams recently updated the practical exam guidelines, and this can be found on the resources page of the MW website. This document, together with the examiner reports, is an invaluable resource to help you succeed in the MW exam.

Paper One Report: Paper Chair, Peter Mitchell MW

General comments

Paper one this year was designed to allow candidates to show their understanding of the wines in terms of quality, winemaking and evolution. Each question also included some reference to style and the ability to succinctly describe this is an important part of the skill set for wine professionals. I am glad to say most achieved this successfully. There are still too many candidates who show significant gaps in theory knowledge about how styles of wine are made, and a number seem to struggle with reading acidity, especially when there is some residual sugar involved. That said, with around a quarter of candidates scoring over 60%, there were a good number of passes with a handful of truly outstanding papers. Once again, I would stress the need to carefully read the question and answer it as it is asked – too many dropped valuable marks on question four, part a by not doing this.

Question one – Sauvignon Blanc/Semillon

Generally very well answered with the vast majority of candidates passing this question. Identification of the varieties was straightforward and virtually every candidate succeeded in this. With a limited number of possible origins, candidates were expected to give strong arguments to achieve maximum marks. There was a clear stylistic and quality difference between the two wines and the superb quality of wine one was expected to be appreciated. For full marks candidates needed to be in Pessac-Léognan and the best considered other possible origins in their argument.

Whilst part c was mostly well answered, some candidates struggled with winemaking, missing oak and seeing malolactic conversion where there was none and not appreciating the outstanding quality of wine one.

Question two – Chardonnay

Being so malleable, Chardonnay has become one of the more challenging varieties to pin down the origins of and this was reflected by very few of the marks available being awarded for getting the origin correct. No candidate identified all the origins correctly – indeed over half did not get a single origin exactly right, however many still managed 5 or 6 marks out of the allotted 8 if their reasoning was sound and their conclusion plausible. Most candidates correctly identified the variety and remembered to draw on all four wines in their arguments. There were some marks collected for those who went with Chenin Blanc, but very few for any other options. Style was generally well answered, quality and maturity less universally so. Many candidates did not pick up on the maturity of wine three or the potential longevity of wine six, and whilst the majority recognised wine four as unexceptional, a significant minority thought it was exceptional quality despite the rather clumsy oak use.

Wines five and six seem, understandably, to have caused the greatest difficulty for origin, with Burgundy being the most popular choices.

Question three – France

The majority were correctly placed in France, with those who went wrong generally favouring Germany or New Zealand, reflecting the clearly cool climate characters of the wines. Wine eight could fit all three, but less so wine nine. Wine seven was identified correctly by many, but good marks could be achieved for other fairly neutral varieties as long as the leesy character and moderate alcohol were picked up on.

Wine nine was a very high quality benchmark example yet nearly as many people went with Pinot Gris as Chenin Blanc – hard to justify with the high level of acidity – and few who placed it in Vouvray recognised the outstanding quality of the wine. Paradoxically those who went with Alsace Pinot gris often gave better quality and maturity answers than those who had Vouvray.

Question four – mixed bag

This was a form of question that had not been used before and seems to have caused issues for many candidates. There were some superb answers to part a) which achieved full marks, but the vast majority of candidates did not seek to answer the question as it was asked, instead just offering some winemaking details.

Across the three wines part a accounted for 15% of the total marks available on the paper and candidates were expected to discuss the relative importance of human inputs vs nature to the finished wines, weaving in details of winemaking and terroir to their answers. The wines were chosen so that the influence of the winemaker was increasingly apparent as one moved from wines ten through to twelve.

Variety and origin saw candidates on more comfortable terrain and as these were fairly unique styles of wine, this part was generally very well answered.

Although candidates were not told in the question whether the wines were blends or single variety wines, in part b of this question it refers to 'variety' when wine eleven was in fact a blend dominated by a single variety. Whilst being a single variety would not preclude the correct identification being made, examiners were aware that this could have caused minor confusion and therefore marked this wine bearing this in mind.

Paper Two Report: Paper Chair, Lisa Perrotti-Brown

MW

General Comments

This year's paper two exam gave a nod to the growing global demand for a broadening range of red wine varieties and styles. We introduced a few new question types and esoteric varieties/regions, while also offering a fair number of classic regions, grapes, and question types. While it was not our intention to throw candidates curveballs, it was clear that, when faced with the unknown, some panicked.

Question one - Cabernet Franc

Cabernet Franc is currently trending and is being adapted to various climates and styles worldwide. This question explored how different styles are achieved by considering climate, the variety's appeal to modern consumers, and winemaking techniques.

Part c of the question required candidates to consider carefully what would be the key influences on style and quality, structuring their answers carefully and being selective in their arguments. Those who identified the grape easily (and many did) generally handled the different parts of the question well, skilfully discussing the three very distinct climates (Loire, Argentina, and Tuscany) and their influence on style.

A few candidates managed to earn good points with convincing arguments for Cabernet Sauvignon or Merlot, placing the third wine in Bordeaux instead of Tuscany.

Question two - the classics - Rhône

This was a set of wines from a classic region, with simply worded questions, but it proved challenging for many candidates. What clearly troubled many was that they couldn't find a Châteauneuf du Pape, Hermitage, or Côte-Rôtie, because they weren't there.

Many tried to shoehorn in one or all of these origins, with patchy results. We do not expect everyone to be able to "nail" a Cornas, but we do expect to see plausible options for a wine of that style, rather than an assumption that it is whatever the candidate has in mind. Anyone who wasn't in the Rhône for this flight struggled to get many marks.

Question 3 - mixed bag - rising star indigenous / non-classic varieties

This was a mixed bag of five wines from five different countries using non-classic/indigenous varieties that are gaining popularity. A lot of leeway was given when finding the identities of the most esoteric wines in this line-up, namely an Austrian Zweigelt and a Greek Xinomavro. Yet there were a few who correctly identified these. Most correctly identified the Beaujolais, while the Portuguese Touriga Nacional and Barbera d'Alba largely garnered logical identifications.

Some candidates were thrown off by part b of this question: "Comment on the quality within the context of wine globally." This type of question has not been asked before, but it is relevant given the esoteric nature of these wines, which are not necessarily competing commercially against others within their region.

Typically, there may be only one or two examples of Austrian Zweigelt or Greek Xinomavro available on a shelf or list. So, the question becomes what other wines around the world they might be competing with, and how they compare qualitatively.

Many points were also lost for "comment on the style and commercial appeal" – a commonly asked question. Too many of the responses were vague and repetitive, failing to connect comments and conclusions to the content of the glass.

One potential pitfall in paper two is candidates relying too much on their noses. It's easy to be misled by the similarities in aromatic and flavour compounds common to many red wines. Often, these aromatic profiles alone can

convince candidates of a wine's identity, leading them to force other important—sometimes more critical—characteristics of the wine, such as tannin, body, alcohol, acidity, or oak use, into a mismatched identity. There was a lot of shoehorning on this year's paper two exam, and ultimately, it led to the failure of many candidates.

Paper Three Report: Paper Chair, Ulf Sjödin MW

General comments

The examiners of paper three were quite impressed with this year's set of papers, particularly when it came to the (critical) focus on quality assessment. In many cases, we saw better arguments than previous years, and many students showed a good understanding of how different styles of wines are made. With that said, there were also students who obviously lack basic knowledge on how fortified or sweet wines are made. Our advice is for everyone to refresh their knowledge on how different wines are made and learn reasonable sugar and alcohol levels for these wines. It is very hard, if not impossible, to pass the MW exam without knowing how Madeira or Sherry is made. Students who claim that Tawny Port is aged in a solera system, or that Amontillado Sherry has 14.5% alcohol, should do some more reading.

Although quality assessment was better this year, we still see students who have problems expressing quality levels. Since this is the most important part of an MW exam, everyone should practice how to communicate quality in a clear way. At student seminars, we keep asking for official quality levels when this is appropriate, and in this paper it was clearly communicated in the third question. We still saw students who gave generic answers although they were arguing for a region where there are clearly defined quality tiers. Some students did communicate official quality levels on question three, but not for wines three, four and six, even though they also had official levels (Beerenauslese, Reserva and VORS). Even if we don't ask for it specifically, we do expect an official quality level if there is one and it is relevant.

Commercial position is still a problem for some students. We expect students to tell us where we can find this wine. On or off trade? Specialist or supermarket? Michelin Star restaurant or the local pub? Local or international? And don't forget to use evidence from the glass in the argument!

Question one – Riesling

Question one was designed to give students something to recognize immediately, and the vast majority identified Riesling as the grape variety. Chenin Blanc was a reasonable option, although the arguments for Chenin relied on students not noticing the low alcohol in wine three. Hard evidence like alcohol and sugar are often more reliable than the flavour profile, but we can get the feeling that students decide the grapes and origin quickly, and then try to make the sugar and alcohol levels fit the argument. First impressions may not always be correct, so students should try to be honest with themselves while taking notes.

Many students were in Germany for wines one and three, and for wine two we allowed many New World origins for a pass mark. Overall, this was the most well answered question of paper three.

Question two – Spain

For question two, the Sherry was a banker for most students, and some even referred to that as an argument for going to Spain on the other two wines, which makes perfect sense. The Cava was also in a rather typical style, so most students got the country of origin right. Given the extremely high quality of the Sherry, all other origins scored very poorly, since it was hard to find good arguments that fitted all three wines unless in Spain.

Wine five was the hardest one of the paper, but we allowed for many alternative answers as long as they fitted the light colour and style of the wine. For winemaking and commercial position we expected students to identify the minimal intervention style of the wine, and we saw some really beautiful answers, but also a surprising number of students who just dismissed the wine as a simple bulk wine of very low quality.

Question three – mixed bag

Question three was a mixed bag, so every wine was effectively a question on its own. This is where theory knowledge was most important, and some students scored very high marks because most of the wines were easily identified if alcohol and sugar levels were accurately analysed. Although we didn't ask for the origin, most students understood that quality and commercial position is hard to answer if there is no attempt to identify the origin. It is difficult to communicate quality in a confident way without ever mentioning a likely origin, but we saw some successful answers that managed not to mention any origin although it was clear that the student had identified the wine correctly.

Since we did not ask for origin, high marks could be awarded to students who still got the style and quality levels correct. Mistaking the Tokaj for a Cru Classé Sauternes of equal quality could still yield a pass mark on that question. On this question, we received some outstanding responses that impressed the examiners. When candidates can convey the genuine pleasure they experience in tasting a 40-year-old Tawny, that enthusiasm is shared by those reading the paper. One candidate, for example, correctly identified the Tokaji as a Szamorodni and reasoned that "although the sugar level suggests 5 or 6 Puttonyos, the exceptional quality indicates a producer whose wines would exceed the minimum sugar levels required for those classifications." It was an insightful observation that instilled much confidence in the eyes of the examiners.